MODULE 29 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

How DOP-C02 Questions Are Written

The format, the anatomy of a question, qualifiers and distractors, multiple response, catalogue drift, and pacing 75 questions in 180 minutes.

DOMAIN All six EXAM WEIGHT 100% MODULE 29 of 34

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Every question is built the same way: a situation with one **planted detail**, a **qualifier**, and options where **more than one works**.

The exam, in facts

ITEM	DETAIL
Questions	75: 65 scored, 10 unscored, and you cannot tell which
Time	180 minutes: about 2.4 minutes per question
Types	Multiple choice, one of four; multiple response, two or more of five or more
Score	Scaled 100 to 1,000; 750 to pass; compensatory across domains
Guessing	No penalty: never leave a question blank
Service names	Short names are used; the Help button lists them

ON THE EXAM

Compensatory means a weak domain can be offset by strong ones. Every question counts the same.

The anatomy of a question

01
Situation
Accounts, services, what exists today.

›

02
Constraints
Numbers and must-haves: RTO, 'automatically'.

›

03
Planted detail
One sentence that decides it.

›

04
Qualifier
LEAST overhead, MOST cost-effective…

›

05
Options
Two work; one fits everything.

ON THE EXAM

The planted detail is often the last sentence of the situation, and often sounds like background.

A reading order that works

- Read the **question sentence** and qualifier first, so you know what you are looking for.
- Then read the situation, noting numbers, 'automatically', 'existing', 'future accounts', 'without code changes'.
- Look for the sentence that sounds like background but rules options in or out.
- Only then read the options, and eliminate before you compare.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Reading options first plants an answer in your head before you know the constraints.

What each qualifier really asks for

QUALIFIER	REALLY MEANS	USUALLY WINS
LEAST operational overhead	Least to run and maintain afterwards	Managed feature over custom code
MOST operationally efficient	Fewest moving parts over time	Native integration
MOST cost-effective	Cheapest that meets every requirement	Not simply the cheapest option
LEAST development effort	Configuration, not code	A setting or managed service
MOST secure	Strongest control that still meets needs	Preventive, least privilege, no long-lived keys
LEAST downtime	Users keep being served	Blue/green, traffic shifting

ON THE EXAM

Cost-effective never means violating a requirement. Eliminate on requirements first, then apply the qualifier.

Seven kinds of wrong answer

DISTRACTOR FAMILY	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Custom code for a native feature	A scheduled Lambda rebuilding a built-in setting
A person in the loop	Manual approval or review where 'automatically' was asked
Retired or legacy service	OpsWorks, Inspector Classic, a polling source
Wrong scope	Region-wide fix for a zone problem, or the reverse
Right service, wrong setting	Recover on an instance check; DLQ for mishandled events
Over-engineered	Multi-Region active-active for an internal tool
Works, but breaks a constraint	Correct technically, fails one stated must-have

ON THE EXAM

Name the family and you can discard the option without fully understanding it.

Multiple response questions

- Read the count: 'Choose TWO' or 'Choose THREE'. There is no partial credit.
- Judge each option as true or false on its own, against every requirement.
- Correct options often form **two halves** of one solution: prevent plus fix, permission plus network.
- Two options that do the same job are rarely both right. Pick the better one and look elsewhere.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> In our question bank analysis, about one question in five was multiple response.

Catalogue drift on the day

- The exam guide predates many changes: retired services may still appear as options.
- Answer on the **guide's terms**: a guide-era correct design is still correct.
- If a newer native feature appears as an option and fits every requirement, it is likely the answer.
- Do not reject an option only because the service has since been renamed.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Module 30 lists every gap between the guide and today, with dates.

Spending 180 minutes

01

Pass one

Answer every question in about 2 minutes. Flag doubts.

02

Checkpoint

At about 120 minutes, all 75 answered.

03

Pass two

Revisit flagged questions with fresh eyes.

04

Final check

No blanks. Every answer has a guess at least.

ON THE EXAM

Non-native English speakers can request 30 extra minutes. Arrange it before booking the exam.

When you are stuck between two

- Find the axis they differ on, from module 28, and ask that question of the situation.
- Reread the last sentence of the situation: it is usually the planted detail.
- Prefer the option that satisfies every constraint over the one that is most impressive.
- Do not change a first answer without a concrete reason you can name.

> ON THE EXAM
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> The sophisticated option is often the over-engineered distractor. Sufficient beats impressive.

> A Lambda function calls a partner API with a key that the partner requires to be rotated every 30 days. Rotating it means calling the partner's API to issue a new key.
>
> Today an engineer rotates it by hand and updates an environment variable. The company wants rotation automated with the LEAST operational overhead.

What should the DevOps engineer do?

A. Store the key in Secrets Manager with a rotation function on a 30-day schedule, and fetch it at run time

B. Store the key in Parameter Store, and build an EventBridge Scheduler job and Lambda function to replace it

C. Have the deployment pipeline generate a new key and update the environment variable monthly

D. Encrypt the environment variable with a customer managed KMS key

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the DevOps engineer do?

A Secrets Manager rotation

Scheduling, staging labels and retries are built in; you only write the partner call.

B Parameter Store plus Scheduler

Works, but you build the scheduling, versioning and failure handling yourself.

C Pipeline updates the variable

Redeploys to rotate a secret, and keeps it in an environment variable.

D Encrypt the variable

Protects it at rest. Still never rotates.

THE METHOD

Anatomy: both A and B work. The qualifier chooses the managed rotation framework.

> Compliance requires one year of VPC Flow Logs for 40 VPCs. The logs are queried a few times a year during investigations, and minutes of query latency are acceptable.
>
> Flow logs currently go to CloudWatch Logs with one-year retention, and the bill is high.

Which solution is the MOST cost-effective?

A Keep CloudWatch Logs, and switch the log groups to the Infrequent Access class

B Stream flow logs into an Amazon OpenSearch Service domain

C Load flow logs into Amazon Redshift through Firehose

D Deliver flow logs to S3, move them to a cheaper storage class after 30 days, and query with Athena

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which solution is the MOST cost-effective?

A Infrequent Access logs

Cheaper ingestion, but a year in CloudWatch still costs far more than S3.

B OpenSearch

A running cluster all year, for a few queries.

C Redshift

A warehouse to run, for rare, simple queries.

D S3, lifecycle, Athena

Cheapest storage, pay-per-query analysis, and minutes of latency is accepted.

THE METHOD

Anatomy: 'a few times a year' and 'minutes acceptable' are the planted details that make S3 and Athena fit.

> An organisation with 90 accounts must stop new public S3 buckets from being created, and fix any bucket policies that are already public. Both must happen automatically.

Which combination of steps meets these requirements? (Choose TWO.)

A Enable GuardDuty S3 Protection in every account

B Enable account-level S3 Block Public Access everywhere, with an SCP denying changes to it

C Have the security team review bucket policies weekly

D An organisation conformance pack with a public-bucket rule and automatic remediation

E Enable Amazon Macie in every account

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which combination of steps meets these requirements? (Choose TWO.)

A GuardDuty S3 Protection

Detects suspicious access. Neither prevents nor fixes public policies.

B Block Public Access, locked by SCP

The preventive half: new public access is blocked, and cannot be turned off.

C Weekly review

Manual, and a week late. 'Automatically' rules it out.

D Conformance pack with remediation

The corrective half: existing public policies are found and fixed.

E Macie

Finds sensitive data and reports bucket posture. It does not fix anything.

THE METHOD

Two requirements, 'stop new' and 'fix existing': expect one preventive and one corrective answer.

> EC2 instances in private subnets with no internet access must be managed through Session Manager. The instances have no instance profile, and none appear as managed nodes.

Which combination of steps will make the instances managed? (Choose TWO.)

A Create interface VPC endpoints for ssm, ssmmessages and ec2messages

B Add a NAT gateway to the private subnets

C Attach an instance profile with the AmazonSSMManagedInstanceCore policy

D Open port 22 in the instances' security group

E Launch a bastion host in a public subnet

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which combination of steps will make the instances managed? (Choose TWO.)

A Three interface endpoints

The network half: a private path to Systems Manager, with no internet.

B NAT gateway

Also a network path, but it gives internet access, which the situation rules out.

C Instance profile

The permission half: the agent can now register. Default host management would also do it.

D Port 22

Session Manager needs no inbound ports at all.

E Bastion host

An SSH pattern Session Manager exists to replace.

THE METHOD

Module 13's checklist: agent, permissions, network path. Two were missing, so two answers.

Module 29 in five lines

- 75 questions, 180 minutes, 750 to pass, no penalty for guessing: never leave a blank.
- Read the question and qualifier first; find the planted detail; eliminate, then compare.
- Name the distractor family to discard options quickly.
- Multiple response: judge each option alone; correct answers are often two halves.
- Answer on the guide's terms; pass one by two hours, then review flags.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Next, module 30: the revision gap. Everything the exam guide says that has since changed.